

Q&A Session: Family Distractions, Selfish to Meditate, Negative Emotions, Suffering on Identification

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 38:11

I have a family of children. How am I supposed to practice with so many distractions?

Yeah, it's best to give them up. This is a very regular problem we come across, isn't it? It's really understanding that meditation isn't sitting on the cushion. Meditation is about developing a type of awareness, a type of being in the present moment, you might say. In the *Satipaṭṭhāna* discourse, this discourse on how to establish awareness, there's a section there on daily life, that when you're stretching your arm, you're stretching your arm. When you're doing this, you're doing that.

So meditation in action is doing something deliberately, doing something that you actually meant to do. There are various ways we can do that. It's basically always to do with attitude. It's always to do with getting the right attitude, and this sets the heart in the right direction. And then that's where you put your attention. So whatever you're doing in daily life, whether you're looking after children or cooking or working, it's important just to stop every so often and put the right intention in your heart. And that's the good heart.

Generally speaking, the attitude in daily life, in terms of work and family and all that, is service. You're serving people. Service. So there's the good heart, and that's where you put your attention. So, just like in meditation, you're washing the pots and you're worried. You find yourself worrying, so you have to stop and decide: now am I going to wash the pots or am I going to worry? And you make a decision: I'm going to wash the pots. So you re-establish your connection with the pots. When you're with children and they're getting up your nose, you stop and you say children are getting up my nose, and you re-establish your sense of service to your children.

And in a busy life, if you can actually find some time to sit in the morning, that's important because that sets your mode for the day. It's like, this is the way I want to be. I want to be bright and I want to be awake all day and aware. And then you always end your practice with this *metta*, so that reconnects you with the world. And even though we do it in a more generalized way, that doesn't mean to say that in that practice, at the end of it, you can't bring people to mind whom you're going to meet during the day. So some of them might be difficult. So you meet them with no ill will. No ill will.

When you meet them, of course, a lot of ill will comes up. But you know, oh, ill will's come up. And then

you re-establish a certain open-heartedness. At least you can establish an attitude of no harm. And there might be a lot of ill will to it, but at least no harm.

And sometimes when things seem to get on top of us, so many things to do all at once, just try to maintain a line of calmness through it. And just know that when you're trying to do two things at once, there's going to be some inefficiency. You can't do it. But sometimes you have to do that. You're trying to cook and the baby's crying and somebody's shouting for you. You're going berserk. You just do the best you can.

But the driving line is just this sense of awareness. And to be aware, you've got to be generally relaxed. Once you get tense, it's very difficult. And a lot of energy gets dissipated with tension and fretting and all that. You just keep stopping. Start again. Even if you have to do that every ten seconds. Start again. It doesn't matter. You just keep stopping and starting again.

So when we talk about meditation in action, we're not talking about being self-aware. That's often a mistake we make because in the practice of *vipassanā*, you become very much self-aware. You become this observer up here somewhere observing. So you think well when I go around life I've got to watch myself doing things, but that's a real split in daily life because one minute we're aware of what we're doing, next minute we're aware of myself doing. So even though self-awareness arises you don't develop it. You know it's there but you keep putting your attention on what you're doing.

And when you enter into an action, no matter what it is – so looking after children, doing the garden, doing a piece of work – when you enter into that and you lose that sense of self, you also lose a sense of time. Then you suddenly wake up and you've been at the computer for ten hours and you wonder where it's all gone. But if you've entered into that absorption with goodwill, with a sense of service and a sense of awakeness, that's what you're developing. If you enter into that absorption with anxiety or with some greed or with some sort of... that's what you're developing.

So once you understand that we develop our personalities and characters by thinking and doing, then you become much more wary about entering into what you're doing with a good intention. And every time you lose it, which we will, you just start again.

And in the Buddha's understanding, you can become fully liberated looking after children. Why not? So it's not to do with sitting on a cushion. I mean, it helps to sit on a cushion, especially at the end of the day, sometime after work, sometime when everything's quiet, even if it's only for ten minutes, and just let the accumulations of the day come up – little anxieties, little irritations.

So that's a time when you just might actually go through the day, and as you remember things, you can feel the emotional value you've put on it. And just to stay with that for a little while, not letting the mind think about it, so you're not trying to work something out, but just staying with the emotional value around it, and just wait for it to soften.

And just to know how attachment manifests. So parents love their children, but there's also always some

attachment there because there's a self. So how do you know when you're acting lovingly and when you're acting from attachment? It's very difficult. But there are certain signs. Whenever you're getting angry with somebody, with your spouse or somebody, that's because you want them to do what you want them to do.

There's a lovely little section in the discourses where there are three fully liberated monks living together. The Anurudhas, they're called. And the Buddha approached them and says, how is it you live so peacefully? I mean, he would turn up at a monastery where the monks were arguing and jumping about and making all sorts of mess. And he said, well, in the morning when I get up, I say to myself: What if I do what the others want to? What if I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do? That puts you immediately into a very different relationship to all the people you meet.

Now, you've got to be careful there because the reason why they were living so peacefully is because the other two were saying the same thing. If you say, why don't I put aside what I want to do and do what the others want to do, then there's a danger, of course, you're going to be manipulated or abused. So you've got to be – it's not stupid. It's not as if it's stupid. But what you're trying to do is to establish a relationship. So you're awake when you see you're being used or abused. Then, of course, you stop it. You're waking up to it.

So the two main things are to remember to develop the good heart through constant intention and to keep putting your attention exactly where you want it. So there are some days where we find it very difficult with the mind so scattered. And you keep getting caught up in things. You get fed up with yourself. You get fed up with everybody else. And there are some days it goes really smooth and you think you've made it. Foolish.

So that's it really. It's very simple. This is what foxes us. We expect it to be clever or difficult. We expect some trick or other to become fully liberated. But it's just getting the right – in daily life, getting the right intention and staying awake. And that little bit about not confusing that self-awareness. What you want to do is to give yourself to what you're doing, so much so that you lose that sense of self, a sense of time. And that's your meditation in action.

Is there any comments on that? Any additions?

How do you tell – you know you're saying about stay awake so you don't get abused – how do you tell the difference between... it's a very hard call to make in practice sometimes I find.

Well, as I say, it's up to the person isn't it to decide whether they're being abused or not? It's up to the person to get that sensitivity and to be able to reflect back to the person how you feel about it without getting angry. I mean, these things aren't hard rules. It's just a case of getting the feel that somebody's messing you about. And you might not know it while it's happening. It might be a reflection afterwards and you think gosh I've been making tea all day for him.

I mean, this problem in a lot of workplaces to do with bullying – things like that can be very subtle.

Bullying can be very subtle. If you're in a position of power over somebody, just ignoring them can be quite destructive. And some people are highly trained to be bullies. They train themselves. They know exactly how to abuse people in this very subtle, easy way. And you wake up, you think, hey, hold on, what's happening? And so that's the waking up, suddenly realising that your service has been abused.

Well, that's very true. Partly it's a habit. It's just getting into the habit of stopping. And the way you can try is that you make a determination. You make a decision to do something. It could be just a phone call. And then you remind yourself, when I put that phone down, I'm just going to stop for a moment. I'm going to go inward and see if there's been any accumulation of something during that phone call. Then the next thing to be done. Before you make a phone call you can stop.

So it's making an intention which is clear and obvious of what you're actually going to do and making it very clear to yourself that when that intention is finished you stop for a moment. It doesn't have to be long. You don't have to sit there for an hour before you can make the next phone call. It's just... Thich Nhat Hanh, he's very good. He has this bell going off at any old time during his monastery. And even when the phone goes, you have to stop. So it's only training.

There's something you can download. I've got it on my computer, this mindfulness bell. Have you come across that? And you can put it on for any length of time – twenty minutes, half an hour. And then you have to train yourself to stop, because sometimes you think, oh, there's a bell, and you get on with it. I've got to get rid of that. So you've got to train yourself to stop and breathe out. Just get that feeling of stopping.

And of course what you find is that you've actually been far more efficient. This is the point. You've been far more efficient. And you've reserved a lot of energy because so much energy goes on emotional stuff which you just don't need. A lot of energy goes in the head. What is it, twenty-five, thirty per cent of our glucose is used by the brain, isn't it? Something crazy like that. So just to relax the brain for a minute. And you do that by just repeating a little mantra to yourself: relax, relax, relax. You have to talk yourself into it.

I always quote Ajahn Tate who was a very lovely teacher in Thailand: take it easy, make it easy. Keep it simple, take it easy, stay with the one who knows. That's it. That's the one you've got to find out. Once you've cracked that you've made it.

I'm just trying to think – instead of saying them as distractions, they're not distractions. They're only distractions to somebody who's intent on doing this even though everything else around them is calling them to do that. But they're not – they're just the next thing to be done. Abandon the word distractions. Is that alright?

Isn't it selfish to meditate so much? Shouldn't we be trying to improve the lives of others in tangible ways?

Yes. The problem is improving others in tangible ways. This is the big problem. Because of the self we tend to improve other people's lives in tangible ways by the way we want to improve them. So we end up with

this do-gooder syndrome. A do-gooder is somebody who wants to do you the good they want to do you. It's irrelevant whether you want it or not, and it makes them feel good. That's the point. They're going to feel goodness.

Sometimes it's not that there's meditation and there is this other thing – they're not opposites. Whatever life we choose to lead, that lifestyle will determine how much time we're putting to meditation, how much time we're not. So if your work is one of these terrible things that you have to keep going on for ten, twelve hours a day, then that's what you have to deal with. And in between time, you try to stop and keep this awakedness going, try to do the morning and evening meditation.

When it says to meditate so much – I mean, what's so much about forty minutes in the morning and twenty minutes in the evening? I mean, that's not so much, is it? I mean, that's your basic template. Forty minutes to an hour in the morning. And then, every so often during the day, try to stop. See if you can stop for ten minutes occasionally. At lunchtime, instead of yackety-yackety, if you find a quiet place, just sit quietly. You don't have to sit in posture. You just find a quiet place to sit and just quieten the mind, quieten the heart – ten minutes, fifteen minutes. And then in the evening when you come back.

Now you wouldn't do that if you didn't see the effect of it on your life. That's the point. I mean, for me it was immediate. As soon as I started meditating my life became so much easier. I was a teacher in an FE school, so you have to go from one class to another sometimes right across the college. So normally speaking you'd be shouting at somebody and then you'd bang the door and then you'd be rushing to the next class with all your stuff under your arm. But then I began to realize through the meditation that the movement from one place to another was a time just to collect yourself. So the whole day became so much calmer – so much calmer, just simple things like that.

And you wouldn't do that if you didn't realize what sort of mind or awareness you're trying to develop. And that's what the *vipassanā* is doing. It's trying to help us realize that there's a way of being aware, which is awake and alive, and it's engaged in the sitting. It's engaged in the sense of really feeling and seeing things. And in the world of doing things, being in your doing, being your doing. Ram Dass, very good book, *Be Here Now* – being your doing. It's an old one but it's still worth reading.

And then you realise that. And then what you discover – I think most people begin to experience is that when they drop, when the meditation drops off, their life starts going back to the old habits. And then you realise: ah, hold on, that was the purpose of my meditation. And then you need little fillips during the year. You need to do a day retreat occasionally if you can get away for a week. And these lift your practice. Lift your practice.

So there's nothing wrong with trying to help people.

It's just that you're not out there for yourself. This is very difficult. You're not out there trying to make yourself happy through helping others. You may be happy helping others, but that's not the reason you're

doing it.

Now you may say to yourself consciously, "Oh I'm doing it for their benefit." And then when somebody—you know, my usual example for those who know me—you make this soup for somebody because they're ill, and they say, "Well I don't want the soup." "Stick with this soup now! Took me two hours." And they say, "Do me a favour." I say, "What's that?" "Clean the toilet. I'd rather have a clean toilet."

"I've made this soup!" Of course you do—you clean the toilet but you're grumbling. And then that awful business of saying yes too quick. "Will you help me move house?" "Oh yeah." "Where's he going?" And you have to start lying. "I feel really ill, I can't go." All sorts of dead ends.

So I would abandon trying to help others. I'd wait for somebody to ask me to help them. That's a safer path. Would anybody like to add to that?

"You said that when we feel strong negative emotions we should allow ourselves to feel them fully and they will burn themselves out. What can we do when the pain of these emotions feel so overwhelming and when we simply feel we do not have the strength to endure until the emotion passes?"

Now when it feels overwhelming like that, you have to park them. I try to make a distinction between suppressing something and parking it. When you suppress something, you're doing it out of anger, you're doing it out of aversion, you're doing it out of fear. When you do that, you're just adding more bad energy into the system. But if you say, "Well this is too much," you say to it, "Stay there for a minute," and I'll have a cup of tea. I'll call up a friend. I'll do something or I'll go for a walk. So you don't have to be overwhelmed in that sense.

Of course sometimes it feels like that because when you open up to yourself, you're taking away these suppressive measures. So you're sitting there, for instance, and the fear comes up and you don't want to feel this, and you're a bit afraid of it—some anxiety, a sense of panic. So you stay with the panic. But when that panic and when that sense of fear of what you're going to experience and the aversion to it disappears, this stuff's then allowed to manifest. So don't be surprised if it comes up with a whoosh.

So then you go, "Whoa, whoa, stop." So you take a walk. And you just wait. And then very slowly your courage comes. You get more courage and you're able to sit with it. And then you're able to sink into it.

One question that you might ask yourself is, "Well, what is an emotion before I give it a name?" Once you give something a name, you're into a reaction. If you don't know what it is and you've lost some fear of it, then you can sink into it more easily. As you know, if you have a pain, a lot of people might feel very sick and they don't know what it is, but it turns out to be a serious disease like cancer. There's a sort of certain relief that they know what it is. It's better to be in a place of knowing what it is than not knowing what it is, even though it's a horrible diagnosis.

So it's the same with these emotions. We don't know the extent of them, the depth of them. And you have to go sometimes a little gingerly, that's all. Gingerly. Does that make sense? Anybody got any other tricks?

"Just persevering. I actually went on a retreat to help me deal with the negative emotion I was having with somebody I had to work with every single day. And it took me three years of visiting, visiting, visiting that emotion. I still have a little bit of a low threshold when I encounter that person. But at least I don't feel this overwhelming ill will."

That's right. And of course we know from Freud that if you do push it away it comes out in sneaky ways. It comes out in little slips of the tongue, just the way you look at them, which makes everything worse. Well, congratulations for not slipping into murder.

"You mentioned earlier when talking about identification that there can be moments of this and all our suffering begins, but identification can often be seen in interpersonal relationships as a kind of empathy with another's pain. Is there wholesome and unwholesome identification, or do we just get it all confused?"

No, when I talk about identification I'm talking about identifying with what is unwholesome. What is unwholesome? When, if you watch how the mind works—say you see somebody whom you don't like—first of all, as soon as you see them, which is the immediate contact, there's a reaction. You don't like. And then there's an identification with that reaction: "I don't like." And this immediately turns into a train of thoughts or an action of speech or body. And that's creating your conditioning, that's your becoming. That's what the Buddha means by becoming, *kamma*.

Now, so long as we are aware of that dislike, we're not developing it. It remains there as a difficult feeling, it remains there as unpleasant, but the one that knows isn't actually suffering until they become "I am angry" or "I am depressed." To make that distinction really, you have to in your meditation, when say a negative state comes up—some sort of anxiety—and you're feeling it, it's become quite objective to you. You feel it.

So just reflect on that. Yes, there's an interior unpleasant feeling, unpleasant environment, interior unpleasant environment. But that which knows isn't actually suffering. It's observing it. If you can make that clear to yourself, then you see that the problem starts when we slip into this "I am"—I am depressed, etcetera.

Now when it's on the positive side—I want to do something for somebody, I love somebody, I'm rejoicing in that person's success—there's still that identification of "I am the one who is rejoicing," "I am the one who loves" and all that. So there's still delusion there, but it's developing the good heart. So in the Buddhist therapy we are letting go of unwholesome states which are causing us problems and we're moving towards wholesome states so that we're developing the beautiful mind.

But the delusion is still there that I am happy, I am the one who's happy, the I business. Now when that is

strong, when the more beautiful the heart is, the easier it is to see that delusion and to drop it. It's very difficult to drop the delusion of I when you're in a lot of pain, when you're in a lot of emotional pain.

Now, if you think of other therapies, other ways of seeing that, in the Christian way, you've got sinfulness. So that's their way of saying this unfortunate conditioning—sinfulness. And on the other side, you've got God and the commandments and the guidance, and you've got this free will. So this free will now has to decide whether it wants to go towards hell or towards heaven. And by realising what the choice is, one hopes to make those choices that are moving us towards heaven.

Now if you look at the Freudian model, instead of sin, you've got id—terrible id, which is animal and dreadful. And on the other side, you've got superego—the voices of your parents and the Bible and the Buddha. And in the middle you've got this poor ego trying to navigate some sort of decent life for itself. So it's always the same thing, it's just looking at it from different angles.

From the Buddha's point of view, the problem is ethical. And that would be the same as the Christian point of view—the problem is ethical, which really in its broadest sense means our relationships. How do you relate to other people? How do you relate to other animals and birds and all that? How do you relate to objects? How do you close your fridge door? Well, you should close it very gently.

So it's by correcting the negative side of us, the unwholesome side, by simply not indulging those intentions. And by indulging those intentions that are beneficial to us. Now there's still a bit of a self there, but we're getting much more beautiful in ourselves. I'm using the word beautiful because that's the way the Buddha talks about the mind—beautiful mind.

So that's what the identification is. So long as there's an identification with this psycho-physical organism as being me, even in the most subtle ways, I'll be seeking happiness through it and it's not going to deliver. So I've got to search for happiness in a different place.

Where are we going to find the happiness the Buddha talks about? So again, like I said this morning, as you relocate back into the knower, into the observer, the feeler, and that becomes a very strong experience for you, separate from the body with its sensations, the heart with its emotions, the mind with its thoughts and images. Even there, afterwards you can reflect, "What was it like being there?"

Now you may at first be very disappointed because it's completely unexciting. But actually there's no suffering there. And the more you stay in that place, even during daily life, even during your actions—which is to be aware, just to be aware—the cooler our lives become. The cooler. And there's a deep happiness because life isn't about chasing the next excitement, it's about meaningfulness.

We'll suffer anything as long as it's meaningful. Take a look at these political activists—torture, all that sort of stuff—but for them it makes their life utterly meaningful and therefore they experience a profound happiness about themselves. How's that then? Any comments? Observations? Criticism?

"How much of your day do you listen to the news or do you..."

Well, unfortunately, I've become a bit of an aficionado. That's because of this damn computer. And you just click and you get BBC and Al Jazeera. Yeah, depressing.

"You don't limit yourself particularly."

Well, I try, you know. When I'm listening to the news, when I remember, I try to send out a bit of a thought of loving kindness to these people. But it's also, remember, that we suffer from a sense of impotence when we see these things. And really that's a case of being humble, which is recognising exactly where we are in the scheme of things when it comes to power. The amount we can do is extraordinarily limited. And the amount that we can influence other people to do what we want them to do is very limited. And it's a case of saying, "Well, that's it, that's all I can do," and being happy with that, being content with it, knowing that you're not asked to do any more. That's the limit of you. And just to accept that we are in fact moving slowly but surely towards complete destruction. Yippee! Let it come, that's what I say.

Being clever animals, we will—you know, a few will survive and write a new book called Survival, which will replace all these other books like the Bible and the Buddha's teachings. Yeah, very unfortunate. What to do?

So yes, we've come to the end a little bit late. Can I leave you with a little blessing? The blessing is: may you enjoy good fortune. May all the gods and beings that can protect us protect you. May the force be with you. And may you receive the blessings of the Bodhidhamma Sangha.

Bhavatu sabba maṅgalaṃ, rakkhantu sabba devatā.

Do you know this one? Oh, you do? Ah, chance to go. No, I just keep it.

Transcriptions produced locally using Swiss low-carbon electricity. Corrections and rewriting by cloud-hosted AI.